Off-Stage

by Matt Mills



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(Rich wearily addresses an audience from his stage.)

RICH. Do you want to hear a joke? The seven worst words in the English language. Right? Have you seen the looks on people's faces when they get asked that? "Do you want to hear a joke?" It's like you've offered them a roadside colonoscopy from a grizzly bear. Truthfully, I think people would prefer bears invading their body rather than jokes invading their ears. What's with that? We live in a world where ten bucks is a fair price for a cup of coffee, but is too much to spend on art? I swear we're all going to be completely illiterate one day.

I am, unfortunately, a stand-up comedian; but no, I do not ask people if they want to hear a joke. That's kind of implied with my line of work. People come and they pay money to sit in a dark room where they have to listen to me say whatever I want! For exactly five minutes, because when that red light goes on you better stop talking. They're serious about that red light, you know. There are "Roxanne" levels of red-light-drama in stand-up.

I started doing shows when I was a kid. When I was only nine months old! *(He looks the audience over.)* Of course not, you jerks! Just because I have a stage doesn't mean you should listen to everything I say! The moon landing was staged! Clinton killed Kennedy! Unicorns exist! Man, I love the gullible.

You know, growing up, my dad introduced me to all the greats...Johnny Carson, Richard Pryor, Lenny Bruce. He was always trying to give me a laugh after he'd given me a bad beating the night before. You see, he worked all day in the mine and would come home drunk and frustrated. The next morning, he'd be a father again. His favorite thing to do was just, well, he'd look at me and say "chin up". Chin up. But it's hard to keep your chin up when you keep getting knocked down.

I was 16 when I actually started doing stand-up in the city. My entire set was based around gym class and my, uh...self-

enjoying habits, we'll call it... I quickly fell in love. Both with stand-up and...Jill *(waves hand)*. I couldn't be stopped...doing stand-up, I mean! Oh man, that feeling when you get on that stage and the light hits you... It feels so warm; it just hypnotizes you. It can fool you into feeling like you belong. It gets addictive.

By 19, I had already done 200 shows. I know, I know—try to keep calm, ladies. Because in spite of all my hard work, those shows got me nowhere. Nothing. I never saw a dime or even an opportunity for one. Every time it was just "good job" but "better luck next time."

I worked full-time down at the docks just to pay rent, and that didn't even leave any money for food…or anything else for that matter. No friends, no fun, no free-time, no joy… Just work and stand-up. My life was one constant struggle to survive. I needed to catch a break just to stay alive.

I entered contest after contest, amateur showcase after amateur showcase. But despite the hard work...the sleepless nights, the paralyzed mornings, that shaky feeling you get when something's wrong...only I had that feeling all day. Every day. Every minute, every second...I couldn't take it. I remember walking up to a producer...

"You know, I've been doing shows here forever. I bring in a crowd, maybe not the biggest, but I know I can do this for real. Please just give me a paid slot. I'm worth the money! Please. I need this. Let me prove it to you."

But I didn't get the chance. Maybe it was the hunger pangs in my stomach, but I just started to get this sick feeling that no one was looking out for me and that everyone was using me. I quickly began to realize I was truly and completely alone—like I didn't belong in the world, like the world doesn't *want* me to belong. I'd leave the clubs, look up at the expensive skyscrapers above me, and for the first time in a while, I felt entirely hopeless.

That's when I got the call. There was this audition. *The* audition. Anyone invited had a shot to show a few club owners that they can hack it professionally. One chance to make it to the big leagues. My big break. All I had to do was go up there, win over the crowd, and they'd start giving me paid shows. Win over the crowd and I'd be able to eat for a little while. Who knows? Maybe I'd even become a success.

I worked on my material for weeks, breathed it in, slept, and had dreams about what I'd say. I imagined the best crowd, the worst crowd, short crowds, tall crowds, white crowds, purple crowds... Down at the docks I'd tell jokes to the guys, use them as a test audience. I'd tell a joke to the street-sweeper as I walked by or the policeman on the corner. There wasn't a second I didn't prepare, because I had no choice. It was either make it or starve.

Finally, the night of the show arrived. They called my name and I'm transported to another world. Like I'm in a trance, I walk on stage, look out at the audience, and give them the best performance of my life. I mean, you should've seen it; it was absolutely incredible. Guys were doing spit-takes and girls were laughing like they were split in half. It didn't seem real. I thought I was in a movie or something. It was my moment. My five minutes of paradise.

After the show, I walked up to the owners to ask what they thought. They just looked at me and said...
(We see Rich react to the owners speaking...)

Better luck next time? Next time? No, you don't understand. There is no next time! This was it. This was my time! Didn't you see them out there? They loved me! They loved me! I got on that stage tonight, and I mattered! No, you don't understand! I haven't eaten this week; my hands are bloody and overworked, I...what did you just say? Chin up? I should just...chin up? I'm a failure. And if there's one thing I've learned, it's that failures don't get to chin up. Failures don't get anything. Failures don't belong in this world, failures get...

(Rich grabs an owner, slams him to the ground and viciously beats him, repeatedly smashing his fist into the owner's skull.)
...beaten and beaten and beaten until they understand they should have never been born!

(Rich gets pulled off the owner, stumbles back, shocked by what he just did. Rich looks to the audience in awe. He looks down to his hands, realizes he's cuffed in a prison cell.)

That was it for me. The end of my career. What career. It was the end of my life. I've been in here for ten years now, and if I promise to be really good, I'll only have ten more. Which sounds pretty easy, since in prison "good behavior" just implies a lack of bad behavior. As if that's what makes you a good person. The lack of evil. But there are good people who do evil things. When all it takes for evil to succeed is for good men to stand by and do nothing...at least I did something.

It's not too bad in here though. I've made some friends I can tell jokes to. Every Friday we have a little open mic here in our cell. It's just a two person open mic, but it's better than nothing. At least in here there are no buildings to stare down at me. Nobody to tell me I don't belong. To chin up. I'm just in here trying to find the beauty in everything. I'm finding it's a lot easier when nobody's holding your eyes shut.